

What is a Photo Printer?

A photo printer is a type of inkjet printer designed specially to print high quality digital photos on photo paper. Some photo printers are equipped with digital media readers to print pictures even without a PC.

In India, until 2004, the home segment had not even begun to take off, and vendors typically targetted the studio lab segment. Industry estimates place photo printer sales at over 10 percent of inkjets sold in India. Of course, the sale of digicams is closely linked with photo printers, along with accessories such as cartridges and paper.

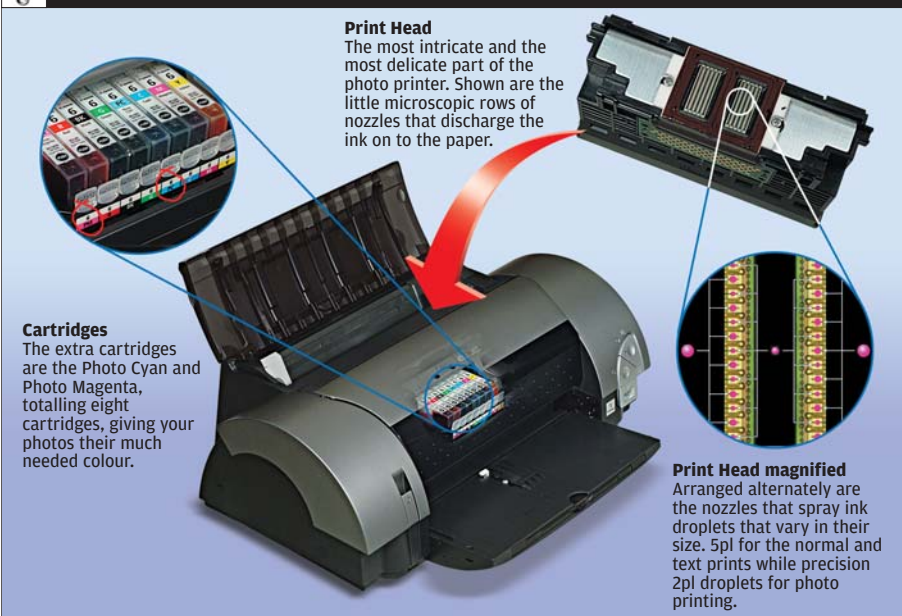
What to Expect in 2005

Ashwini Aggarwal, country marketing manager (consumer), Imaging and Printing Group, Hewlett Packard India Sales, confirms that HP will focus its photo printers for the small and medium business segment this year. Says he: "There are subtle differences between camera prints and between those a photo printer offers, but the gap is constantly narrowing." HP is also targeting studios, where photo printers have enabled faster processing of passport size prints.

HP is also investing in marketing campaigns to encourage its digicam customers to print their photos at home or at work.

Epson is the latest entrant in the photo printer market, and says that sales of photo printers have been brisk (around 2000 a month until December 2004). Suresh Govindachari, senior business manager (consumer products), Epson, admits that photo printers will never completely replace ordinary camera prints. "But we are looking at the more than one lakh photo studios in the smaller, semi-urban centres apart from the city-based studios. Habit conversion is key to our campaign. People realise slowly that the main advantage of photo printers is the

How A Photo Printer Works



convenience factor—prints are made available immediately, and the cost per print is much lower than camera prints."

He adds: "Colour restoration on old, faded prints is another major area where photo printers score. Many people have sentimental attachment towards old photographs. They want black and white prints converted to colour or blown up to bigger sizes."

Epson's flagship piece is the RX 630, which among other things can print directly from the negative or a digicam memory card.

Canon's success in the photo printer segment has largely ridden the digicam / hand-held wave, and will continue that way this year. But they are slightly more bullish than Epson. "Soon," says Kumar Soni, assistant manager (product marketing), Canon, "all printers sold will be photo printers." Currently photo printers for the home segment are sold in the price range of Rs 8000 to Rs 25,000. Canon will also aggressively market high-end photo printers for the business domain.

To increase public usage of its consumer products in India, Canon recently launched "Canon Digiphot Zones," in collaboration with photo studios across the country. These zones would act as 'one-stop shops' for instant processing of rolls, and as retail outlets for Canon products. Canon will be supplying these studios with digital cameras, film scanners, photo printers and other related accessories.

Mumbai resident and amateur photographer Y P Kaushal recently purchased a Canon Pixma IP 3000, to "make bulk prints in the convenience of my home." Although it's not exactly cost-effective for home users, photo printers score when it comes to ease of use, and saves the consumer a trip to the photo studio.

It is this convenience factor that will make adoption of photo printers a common thing in 2005.■

Who Needs Photo Printers?

Photo printers are available for home as well as for businesses. At home, they serve the purpose of having a photo lab as and when you need it. Borderless printing, which was not possible except in print labs is now possible at home. You can print in regular sizes, and also photo print on stickers and other media.

For businesses, a photo printer may be advantageous if you need good quality prints regularly. For example, if you need to send out a few exclusive, high-quality invites to some clients, you may find it difficult to get it done from your regular print shop. Photo printers can be useful for creative designers, architects and engineers; there are many applications, such as AutoCAD, which make a photo printer a very handy thing to have.



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